

UPSC Intel · Daily Brief

SATURDAY, 26 SEPTEMBER 2026

21 must-know stories, 22 Prelims facts, 15 editorials and 12 explainers, picked from 611 stories reported. Each item links to its source; notes quote the reports.

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MUST-KNOW

High-yield stories: make notes on these. Grouped by syllabus area.

Polity & Constitution

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Election Commissioner Appointments Give Executive Majority to Prime Minister-Led Panel; Supreme Court Refers Challenge to 2023 Law to Five-Judge Constitution Bench

The matter was placed before the Supreme Court for judicial review regarding the executive majority created in the appointment panel by the 2023 legislation. The Supreme Court referred petitions challenging the 2023 law on Election Commissioner appointments to a five-judge Constitution bench.

When: 2023-2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, Prime Minister-led panel · **Prelims:** The law in question was enacted in 2023.; The challenge has been referred to a five-judge Constitution bench.; The selection panel includes the Prime Minister and a Union Cabinet Minister.

Why it matters — It tests the boundaries of executive power versus judicial interpretation in safeguarding independent institutions.; It is crucial for maintaining public trust in the conduct of free and fair elections in India.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment, Appointment

[Raw Law: read the source](#) · also reported by [Lawtext](#), [The Hindu](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi | Dissent in the Election Commission

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi met to address decisions on internal issues raised over the past 10 months. Joshi and Sandhu had earlier recorded objections on at least 14 occasions regarding decisions issued without their knowledge or full commission approval. Commissioners objected to modifying statutory Form 6 for voter registration without amending the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. The Election Commission stated that the additional SIR-related declaration added to online Form 6 was upheld by the Supreme Court. A committee headed by a senior deputy election commissioner with an IIT or IIIT expert will review the ECINET platform to check compliance with laws. Addressing software issues in Goa where 97 eligible voters were left out, the poll panel directed BLOs to collect forms and upload documents on ECINET. The EC announced that agendas for all commission meetings will be circulated in advance and formal minutes will be issued. The commission clarified that disputed IT work-redistribution orders were never implemented after the two commissioners intervened.

When: September 26 and 27, 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi, India · **Who:** Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, Election Commissioner Sukhbir Singh Sandhu, Election Commissioner Vivek Joshi, Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan · **Prelims:** Form 6 is used for enrolling new voters under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960.; The ECINET platform is used by the Election Commission for managing electoral rolls and IT systems.; Cabinet Secretary T V Somanathan was written to by the commissioners over changes in IT work distribution.

Why it matters — Highlights internal accountability, institutional transparency, and dissent within constitutional bodies.; Demonstrates the role of election commissioners in overseeing IT systems, statutory rules, and administrative workflows.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Appointment

[The Hindu: read the source](#) · [free copy on ptinews.com](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

PFI-linked UAPA case: Supreme Court overturns default bail, directs accused to surrender

The Supreme Court's order overturning the default bail and directing surrender put the PFI-linked UAPA case back in the news. The Supreme Court cancelled the default bail granted to an accused person in a case linked to the Popular Front of India and ordered them to surrender.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court, PFI-linked accused · **Prelims:** The case involves the Popular Front of India (PFI).; The legal framework involved is the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act (UAPA).; The Supreme Court issued the directive to surrender.

Why it matters — Reiterates the judicial approach towards statutory bail under stringent anti-terror laws like UAPA.; Highlights the legal complexities surrounding default bail provisions in high-profile terror investigations involving organizations like the PFI.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution, Internal Security · **Prelims angle:** Judgment

[Organiser: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Centre Can Authorise Officer To File Companies Act Fraud Complaint Alongside SFIO: SC [Read Order]

The Supreme Court issued a significant order regarding the authorisation of officers to file fraud complaints under the Companies Act. The Supreme Court held that the Central Government holds the authority to empower an officer to file a complaint for corporate fraud under the Companies Act, in addition to the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO).

When: 26 September 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Supreme Court of India, Central Government, SFIO · **Prelims:** Statute involved: Companies Act.; Key body: Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO).

Why it matters — Clarifies the statutory powers of the Central Government in prosecuting corporate frauds.; Ensures multiple investigative and filing mechanisms can operate to tackle financial crimes.

Syllabus: GS2: Polity & Constitution · **Prelims angle:** Act/Bill/Rules

[LawStreet Journal: read the source](#)

Governance & Policy

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026 and States' Opposition to it

The Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act, 2026 restricts specified state levies on mineral rights and mineral-bearing land to establish fiscal uniformity. The law extinguishes unpaid or unrecovered dues arising from such levies imposed before it comes into force. The amendments override key financial aspects of the Supreme Court ruling dated July 25, 2024, which had upheld states' exclusive power to tax mineral rights. Mineral-rich states fear significant reduction in own-source revenue, as mining contributes substantially to their non-tax receipts. In 2024-25, mineral and petroleum receipts constituted 23 percent of Odisha's revenue receipts, 13 percent of Jharkhand's, and 5 percent of Chhattisgarh's. Odisha's opposition alleged that the law could result in annual revenue losses of around Rs. 12,000 crore and arrears of about Rs. 1 lakh crore. The Centre argues that excessive state-level levies increase mineral costs, fueling inflation and infrastructure expenses while harming investment certainty. The Mines Ministry stated that around 14 levies in the mineral sector will continue, but their combined burden will not exceed a decided percentage after state consultation.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Government, Mines Ministry, and Mineral-rich States like Odisha, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh · **Prelims:** The Supreme Court ruling upholding states' exclusive power to tax mineral rights occurred on July 25, 2024.; In 2024-25, mineral and petroleum receipts made up 23 percent of Odisha's revenue receipts.; In 2024-25, mineral and petroleum receipts made up 13 percent of Jharkhand's revenue receipts.

Why it matters — It directly impacts the fiscal autonomy and non-tax revenues of mineral-rich states like Odisha, Jharkhand, and Chhattisgarh.; It raises important questions about fiscal federalism and the constitutional balance between Union regulation and state taxation powers.

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: Governance & Policy, Polity & Constitution, Geography · **Prelims angle:** Act/Bill/Rules

[ForumIAS: read the source](#) · also reported by [Deccan Herald](#)

International Relations

GS2 GS3

MAKE NOTES

UN Convention against Cybercrime

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar signed the United Nations Convention against Cybercrime to strengthen global efforts against digital threats. The treaty is a landmark global agreement adopted by 193 UN member states and serves as the first legally binding UN instrument on cybercrime. The UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) acts as the secretariat for the convention. Adopted by the UN General Assembly in 2024, the convention entered into force in 2025 after securing 40 signatures in Hanoi, Vietnam. By the end of 2025, a total of 93 countries had signed the convention. The treaty requires member states to enact domestic laws criminalizing unauthorized access to information and communication systems. It mandates states to criminalize the production, sale, distribution, and broadcasting of child sexual exploitation material. The convention also provides for the recovery of cybercrime proceeds and promotes international cooperation while respecting state sovereignty.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** Hanoi, Vietnam · **Who:** External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) · **Prelims:** Adopted by 193 UN member states.; Secretariat is the UN Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC).; Entered into force in 2025 after securing 40 signatures in Hanoi, Vietnam.

Why it matters — *It marks the first international criminal justice agreement in over two decades.; It enhances international cooperation in cybercrime investigations, prosecutions, and the recovery of proceeds.*

Syllabus: GS2 / GS3: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[ForumIAS: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

India and GCC Launch Free Trade Agreement Negotiations

India and the Gulf Cooperation Council formally launched negotiations for a Free Trade Agreement through a Joint Statement signed on 24 February 2026 in New Delhi. The Joint Statement was signed by India's Union Minister of Commerce and Industry, Piyush Goyal, and GCC Secretary General, Jasem Mohamed Albudaiwi. The Terms of Reference for the FTA were signed earlier on 5 February 2026 to set the negotiation framework. The GCC is a regional political and economic grouping of six Arab states in West Asia, established in 1981 with headquarters in Riyadh. Bilateral trade between India and the GCC reached USD 178.56 billion in FY 2024-25, including USD 56.87 billion in exports and USD 121.68 billion in imports. Negotiations were temporarily stalled in June 2026 due to the West Asia crisis before talks resumed in August 2026 in Riyadh. The proposed FTA covers merchandise trade, services, investment, digital trade, and emerging technologies.

When: 24 February 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi and Riyadh · **Who:** Piyush Goyal (Union Minister of Commerce and Industry) and Jasem Mohamed Albudaiwi (GCC Secretary General) · **Prelims:** GCC was established in 1981 with headquarters in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia.; GCC member states: Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, and the United Arab Emirates.; India-GCC bilateral trade reached USD 178.56 billion in FY 2024-25.

Why it matters — *Deepens economic integration with India's largest trading partner bloc.; Secures vital energy supplies, merchandise trade, and interests of the Indian expatriate workforce in West Asia.*

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[gktoday.in: read the source](#) · [also reported by India's News.Net](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Terrorism, global conflicts, 4F crisis, India's development story: Jaishankar at UNGA

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar addressed the 81st United Nations General Assembly, addressing global conflicts, terrorism, and pressures on the Global South. Without naming Pakistan, Jaishankar criticised a serial practitioner of terrorism for misrepresenting facts and trying to normalise terrorism. He asserted India's right to self-defence against terrorism and reaffirmed India's unwavering zero-tolerance approach. Jaishankar called attacks on commercial shipping and seafarers in international waters unacceptable, urging de-escalation in the Gulf conflict. He backed efforts to end the war in Ukraine and reiterated India's support for a two-state solution in West Asia. Jaishankar warned against the weaponisation of everything, citing disruptions in supply chains, market access restrictions, and the use of finance and technology as leverage. He highlighted the 4F crisis faced by the Global South, covering food, fuel, fertiliser, and finance. India's global development contributions were highlighted, noting 600 major development projects executed across 78 countries.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** United Nations, New York · **Who:** S Jaishankar (External Affairs Minister of India) · **Prelims:** Jaishankar addressed the 81st United Nations General Assembly.; The Global South is facing a 4F crisis involving food, fuel, fertiliser, and finance.; India has undertaken 600 major development projects in 78 countries.

Why it matters — *Reiterates India's firm stance against cross-border terrorism and defends its right to self-defence on international platforms.; Highlights the disproportionate vulnerabilities faced by the Global South due to geopolitical tensions and economic weaponisation.*

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations, Internal Security

[indiatoday.in: read the source](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

IMEC gets a Trump boost as the India-Middle East-Europe trade route remains a work in progress

US President Donald Trump renewed Washington's support for the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor during a meeting at the United Nations General Assembly in New York. Trump stated the corridor would help bypass vulnerable maritime checkpoints and reduce regional dependence on insecure routes amid Iranian attacks. IMEC was unveiled in September 2023 via an MoU signed by India, the US, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, France, Germany, Italy and the European Union at the New Delhi G20 summit. The project features an eastern corridor connecting India to the Gulf and a northern corridor linking the Gulf to Europe using a combination of maritime shipping and rail transport. The infrastructure includes plans for electricity cables, digital connectivity, and a pipeline for clean hydrogen, with the UAE serving as a key maritime gateway. Union Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal stated in April 2025 that IMEC could reduce logistics costs by up to 30 percent and transportation time by 40 percent. The corridor provides India with an alternative route to European markets, bypassing the Red Sea route currently facing repeated security threats and disruptions.

When: September 2023 · **Where:** New York, Middle East, India, Europe · **Who:** Donald Trump, Piyush Goyal · **Prelims:** IMEC was signed on the sidelines of the G20 summit in New Delhi in September 2023.; Founding signatories include India, the US, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, France,

Germany, Italy and the European Union.; The corridor is projected to reduce logistics costs by up to 30 percent and transportation time by 40 percent according to Piyush Goyal.

Why it matters — Offers India a reliable alternative export route to Europe that bypasses unstable zones like the Red Sea and Strait of Hormuz.; Aims to significantly reduce transportation costs and travel times while boosting supply-chain resilience and digital infrastructure.

Syllabus: GS2: International Relations

[theprint.in: read the source](#)

Social Justice & Welfare

GS1 GS2

MAKE NOTES

Muslim marriage cannot override POCSO law: Delhi High Court

The Delhi High Court ruled that a Muslim marriage cannot exempt an adult male from criminal liability under the POCSO Act and the BNS for sexual intercourse with a minor wife. Justice Sanjeev Narula pronounced the judgment on September 23, dismissing a couple's plea to quash criminal proceedings against the 28-year-old man. The couple argued the marriage was valid under Muslim personal law as the female had attained puberty before marrying at age 16. The court emphasized that personal laws cannot create an exemption from criminal liability under parliamentary statutes enacted to protect children. The bench stated that marriage does not advance a child's age, and a person aged 16 before the ceremony remains 16 afterwards. The court noted that both the POCSO Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023, set 18 as the threshold for sexual consent without any marital exception for minor wives. Reference was also made to the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006, which defines a female below 18 years as a child. The matter came to light in 2026 when the girl approached a government hospital while about eight months pregnant.

When: September 23, 2026 · **Where:** Delhi · **Who:** Justice Sanjeev Narula, Delhi High Court · **Prelims:** The POCSO Act and the BNS set 18 years as the threshold for sexual consent.; The Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006 defines a female below 18 years as a child.; The judgment was delivered by Justice Sanjeev Narula of the Delhi High Court on September 23, 2026.

Why it matters — Reaffirms the supremacy of parliamentary criminal legislation over personal laws concerning the protection of minors.; Clarifies that the age of consent under the POCSO Act and the BNS (18 years) cannot be substituted by the concept of puberty under personal law.

Syllabus: GS1 / GS2: Social Justice & Welfare, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

[The Hindu: read the source](#) · [free copy on newsx.com](#)

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Child drug abuse is a child protection issue, not just health: CJI Surya Kant

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant stated that children in need of care and protection must not face humiliation, stigma, or exclusion. CJI emphasized that confidentiality and dignity are core to effectively rehabilitating vulnerable children and preventing them from remaining silent. Agencies must adopt a child-sensitive approach to re-integrate children by restoring their childhood and protecting their physical, mental, and personal worth. CJI Kant addressed a seminar in Patna titled Restoring Childhood, Preventing Drug Abuse and Re-integration of Children in Need of Care and Protection. Quoting an August 2026 study in The Lancet Regional Health – Southeast Asia, CJI noted over one in five teenagers in India face moderate-to-high substance risk. Substance abuse among children must be viewed as both a public health concern and a child protection concern, according to the CJI. While the law must respond firmly to perpetrators who exploit children and circulate drugs, the true measure of rehabilitation is societal re-integration without stigma. CJI highlighted that judiciary, government, police, health and education systems, child-care institutions, and civil society must work together collectively.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** Patna · **Who:** CJI Surya Kant, Patna High Court Chief Justice V Kameswar Rao, CNLU Vice Chancellor Faizan Mustafa · **Prelims:** Over one in five teenagers in India are at moderate-to-high risk of substance use according to an August 2026 study in The Lancet Regional Health – Southeast Asia.; The seminar was held in Patna.; CJI Surya Kant participated in an open-house dialogue at Chanakya National Law University (CNLU), Patna.

Why it matters — Highlights the growing crisis of substance abuse among teenagers based on recent scientific studies like The Lancet.; Shifts the administrative and judicial narrative around juvenile substance abuse from a purely criminal or health-centric lens to a holistic child-protection approach.

Syllabus: GS2: Social Justice & Welfare, Polity & Constitution, Health

[Hindustan Times: read the source](#) · [also reported by rediff.com](#)

Health

GS2

MAKE NOTES

Arogya Manthan 2026 Marks Eight Years of AB PM-JAY and Five Years of ABDM

Arogya Manthan 2026 was held at Vigyan Bhawan in New Delhi on 25 September 2026, marking eight years of AB PM-JAY and five years of ABDM. The event was organised by the National Health Authority to bring together stakeholders of India's health assurance and digital health systems. AB PM-JAY has covered over 60 crore beneficiaries, facilitated more than 13 crore hospital admissions, and crossed Rs. 2 lakh crore in treatment value. The AB PM-JAY scheme now includes all senior citizens aged 70 years and above irrespective of socio-economic status, along with ASHA and Anganwadi workers. Under ABDM, more than 97.8 crore ABHA IDs were created and over 121 crore health records were linked by 1 September 2026. New digital tools launched include the NHPR Mobile App, NHCX Implementation Guide, Model Digital Health Facility Guidebook, Secure Data Environment, and Auto-Adjudication Framework. The Secure Data Environment application was developed by the National Health Authority with support from the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru. Jammu and Kashmir was recognised as the Best Performing Union Territory, while Chhattisgarh, Maharashtra, and Gujarat were acknowledged for inter-state portability claim settlements.

When: 25 September 2026 · **Where:** Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi · **Who:** National Health Authority · **Prelims:** AB PM-JAY was launched on 23 September 2018.; ABDM was launched nationwide on 27 September 2021.; Over 97.8 crore ABHA IDs were created by 1 September 2026.

Why it matters — Demonstrates the scale of India's public health assurance and digital health integration.; Highlights expansion of universal health coverage to senior citizens aged 70 and above.

Syllabus: GS2: Health · Prelims angle: Scheme

[ajktoday.in: read the source](#)

Economy

GS3

MAKE NOTES

India to keep taxation out of bilateral investment treaty framework; Cabinet note ready

The Union Cabinet is expected to soon clear a revamped model Bilateral Investment Treaty framework for India. The draft text of the new BIT framework has been finalized and sent to the Union Cabinet for approval. Taxation policy will be kept out of the BIT framework to protect Parliament's sovereign right to decide taxes. Foreign investors must exhaust local legal remedies as the first option before moving to international arbitration. India has already initiated negotiations with four to five countries based on the new model BIT framework. Four BITs are currently being finalized, with negotiations underway involving countries like Canada, Russia, and the UK. India last finalized a model BIT in 2015, which investors often described as restrictive due to the local remedies clause. The government aims to boost foreign capital flows and support free trade agreements, including with the European Union.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union Cabinet, Finance Ministry, Foreign Investors · **Prelims:** India's previous model Bilateral Investment Treaty was finalized in the year 2015.; The new model BIT framework keeps taxation completely out of its treaty scope.; Foreign investors under the framework must exhaust domestic legal remedies before pursuing international arbitration.

Why it matters — Reaffirms India's sovereign right to independently formulate and execute taxation policies without external treaty interference.; Strengthens the domestic judicial system by making local legal recourse mandatory for foreign investors prior to international arbitration.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy, International Relations, Governance & Policy · Prelims angle: Agreement/MoU

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [free copy on business today.in](#) · also reported by [The Hindu](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

RBI withdraws relaxation on export earnings repatriation

The RBI made this regulatory change to increase dollar liquidity and support the Indian rupee. The Reserve Bank of India reduced the export earnings repatriation timeline from 15 months back down to 9 months. The new deadline set is 9 months for bringing back export proceeds into the country. Additionally, the RBI has provided banks with expanded powers concerning trade transactions before the new rules take effect.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Reserve Bank of India (RBI) · **Prelims:** New export earnings repatriation deadline: 9 months.; Previous export earnings repatriation deadline: 15 months.; Regulating authority: Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

Why it matters — Increases dollar availability in the domestic market.; Provides support to the Indian rupee against foreign exchange fluctuations.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy

[Economic Times: read the source](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Centre cuts FY27 market borrowing to Rs 15.99 lakh crore; targets longer debt maturity

The Union government reduced its total market borrowing for FY27 to Rs 15,99,506 crore from the Budget estimate of Rs 17.2 lakh crore. The reduction of Rs 1,20,494 crore is mainly due to switching government securities worth Rs 1,14,286 crore due for redemption in FY27. The government will raise Rs 7.86 lakh crore through securities in the second half of 2026-27 in consultation with the RBI. Of the second-half borrowing, Rs 15,000 crore will be raised through Sovereign Green Bonds. Gross market borrowing for the first half ending in September is expected to be Rs 8,13,506 crore against the Rs 8.2 lakh crore target. The second-half borrowing will happen via 23 weekly auctions covering maturities from three years to 50 years. The 10-year segment accounts for the largest share at 26.3 per cent, followed by the 15-year segment at 17.6 per cent. The RBI fixed the Ways and Means Advances limit for the second half at Rs 50,000 crore to meet temporary cash mismatches.

When: 2026-27 · **Where:** India · **Who:** Union government, Finance Ministry, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) · **Prelims:** Total FY27 revised gross market borrowing: Rs 15,99,506 crore.; Second half FY27 borrowing amount: Rs 7.86 lakh crore.; Sovereign Green Bonds second half allocation: Rs 15,000 crore.

***Why it matters** — Lower market borrowing eases pressure on bond yields and frees up capital for private sector credit demand.;*

Switching and buybacks of securities help smoothen the government's redemption profile over coming years.

Syllabus: GS3: Economy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

[Economic Times: read the source](#) · [free copy on msn.com](#)

Agriculture & Allied

GS3

MAKE NOTES

India bans sugar exports with immediate effect until September 2026

The Ministry of Commerce and Industry prohibited sugar exports with immediate effect until September 30, 2026, or until further orders. The export policy for raw sugar, white sugar, and refined sugar was shifted from 'Restricted' to 'Prohibited'. The Directorate General of Foreign Trade stated the ban aims to ensure adequate domestic availability and maintain food security. Exemptions are granted for exports to the EU and US under CXL and Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) arrangements. Shipments under the Advance Authorisation Scheme will continue under the Foreign Trade Policy 2023. Consignments already in the export pipeline, where loading commenced or shipping bills were filed before the notification, are exempted. Sugar exports may still be permitted to specific countries for their food security upon formal government requests. If not extended, the sugar export policy will automatically revert from 'Prohibited' back to 'Restricted' after September 30, 2026.

When: Wednesday (Notification issued, effective till September 30, 2026) · **Where:** India · **Who:** Ministry of Commerce and Industry, Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) · **Prelims:** The export policy for sugar under ITC (HS) Codes 1701 14 90 and 1701 99 90 was amended from 'Restricted' to 'Prohibited'.; The ban remains effective until September 30, 2026, or until further orders.; Exemptions include shipments under CXL and TRQ to the EU and US, and the Advance Authorisation Scheme.

***Why it matters** — Helps control domestic sugar prices and stabilizes local market availability.; Demonstrates the government's prioritization of food security over international trade commitments, barring specific exemptions.*

Syllabus: GS3: Agriculture & Allied, Economy

[ddnews.gov.in: read the source](https://ddnews.gov.in/read-the-source)

Environment & Ecology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Tiger Reserves Face New Management Test: MEE-TR 2026 Adds Solid Waste as Key Criterion

Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav launched the inception workshop for the 6th Cycle of Management Effectiveness Evaluation of Tiger Reserves (MEE-TR 2026) in New Delhi. The nationwide assessment will cover all 58 tiger reserves in India and is organised by the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) in collaboration with the Wildlife Institute of India (WII). Solid waste management has been introduced as a separate evaluation criterion, covering waste at forest chowkis, tourism waste, and biomedical waste at rescue centres. The MEE framework is adapted from the IUCN World Commission on Protected Areas (WCPA) framework and assesses six elements: Context, Planning, Inputs, Processes, Outputs, and Outcomes. Five previous MEE-TR cycles have been completed in 2006, 2010, 2014, 2018, and 2022, covering 28, 39, 43, 50, and 51 tiger reserves respectively. The sixth cycle will focus on field-based evidence, management outcomes, emerging threats, digital and spatial information, and landscape connectivity. Independent multidisciplinary teams will conduct the assessments to identify strengths, gaps, and areas requiring attention across tiger reserves. India has demarcated more than 85,000 square kilometres for tiger conservation, combining scientific methods with local ecological considerations.

When: 26 September 2026 · **Where:** New Delhi · **Who:** Union Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav, National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA), Wildlife Institute of India (WII) · **Prelims:** Total number of tiger reserves to be assessed in MEE-TR 2026 is 58.; Area demarcated for tiger conservation in India is more than 85,000 square kilometres.; MEE-TR 2026 is organised by the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA) and the Wildlife Institute of India (WII).

Why it matters — It introduces rigorous accountability by adding solid waste management as an evaluation parameter for tiger reserves.; It helps identify management gaps, emerging threats, and strengths across all 58 tiger reserves through independent multidisciplinary teams.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology · Prelims angle: Species

[indianmasterminds.com: read the source](https://indianmasterminds.com/read-the-source)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Vedanta seeks Niyamgiri mining revival, pitches Rs. 1 lakh crore Odisha investment

Vedanta chairman Anil Agarwal renewed a push to revive the shelved Niyamgiri bauxite project after meeting Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi. The Odisha government assured support for necessary permissions to operate the Niyamgiri project and create employment for tribals. The Niyamgiri hills are estimated to hold around 80 million tonnes of bauxite reserves. In 2013, Vedanta's mining project was scrapped after all 12 local Dongria Kondh village councils unanimously voted against it following a Supreme Court order. Vedanta announced plans to invest around Rs. 1 lakh crore in Odisha across mining, aluminium, refining, and downstream manufacturing. Proposed projects include a 3 million tonnes per annum aluminium smelter in Dhenkanal, a 6 million tonnes per annum alumina refinery in Rayagada, and a brownfield expansion of 1 MTPA in Jharsuguda. Agarwal also proposed establishing a 1000-bed super specialty hospital in western Odisha. The Chief Minister stated that the state government is keen on creating massive job opportunities and will support investments in aluminium.

When: Saturday · **Where:** Odisha, Niyamgiri Hills, Dhenkanal, Rayagada, Jharsuguda · **Who:** Anil Agarwal (Vedanta Chairman), Mohan Charan Majhi (Odisha Chief Minister), Dongria Kondh community · **Prelims:** Niyamgiri hills hold an estimated 80 million tonnes of bauxite reserves.; Dongria Kondh is a primitive tribal community (PVTG) residing in the Niyamgiri region.; Vedanta proposed a 3 MTPA aluminium smelter in Dhenkanal district and a 6 MTPA alumina refinery in Rayagada district.

Why it matters — Highlights the ongoing tensions between industrial growth, mineral exploitation, and tribal rights in resource-rich states like Odisha.; Reopens critical questions regarding the implementation and judicial precedents of Gram Sabha veto powers under Indian forest and environmental jurisprudence.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Social Justice & Welfare, Infrastructure & Energy · Prelims angle: Data/Stats

[The Hindu: read the source](#) · [free copy on newindianexpress.com](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

The human cost of conservation

It is in the news due to the Supreme Court eviction order aimed at protecting the Srivilliputhur-Meghamalai Tiger Reserve's ecology. A humanitarian crisis has emerged in 98 forest hamlets in Tamil Nadu's Meghamalai hills following a Supreme Court eviction order against encroachers. A humanitarian crisis is unfolding in 98 forest hamlets in Tamil Nadu's Meghamalai hills following the Supreme Court's eviction order against "encroachers" in a bid to protect the fragile ecology of the Srivilliputhur-Meghamalai Tiger Reserve.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** Tamil Nadu's Meghamalai hills · **Who:** Supreme Court · **Prelims:** Location: Meghamalai hills, Tamil Nadu; Affected areas: 98 forest hamlets; Protected area involved: Srivilliputhur-Meghamalai Tiger Reserve

Why it matters — Highlights the persistent friction between wildlife conservation efforts and the rights of forest-dwelling communities.; Raises important questions about the humanitarian impacts of judicial eviction orders in ecologically sensitive zones.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Polity & Constitution · Prelims angle: Judgment

[Frontline: read the source](#)

GS3

MAKE NOTES

Microplastic pollution surges across the Hindu Kush Himalaya, threatening over 2 billion lives dependent on 'Asia's Water Tower'

A recent research report highlighted the surge of microplastic pollution across the Hindu Kush Himalaya. Microplastic pollution has been reported to be surging across the Hindu Kush Himalaya region, raising severe concerns for environmental and human health.

When: 2026-09-26 · **Where:** Hindu Kush Himalaya · **Who:** Researchers and local populations · **Prelims:** Hindu Kush Himalaya is referred to as Asia's Water Tower.; Over two billion lives depend on the region.

Why it matters — Threatens the water security and health of over two billion people dependent on the region's rivers.; Highlights the growing reach of anthropogenic pollution into remote and vulnerable high-altitude ecosystems.

Syllabus: GS3: Environment & Ecology, Geography

[Research Matters: read the source](#)

Science & Technology

GS3

MAKE NOTES

DRDO's Rs 500 cr quantum bet: Big deep-tech deal to build India's first 20 mK quantum refrigerator

The Rs 500 crore quantum tech deal by DRDO to develop critical cryogenic infrastructure was reported in the news. DRDO has signed a major deep-tech deal worth Rs 500 crore to build India's first 20 mK quantum refrigerator.

When: 2026 · **Where:** India · **Who:** DRDO (Defence Research and Development Organisation) · **Prelims:** DRDO announced a Rs 500 crore quantum deal.; The target is to build India's first 20 mK quantum refrigerator.

***Why it matters** — Provides critical cryogenic infrastructure needed for India's indigenous quantum computing mission.; Boosts domestic deep-tech capabilities and reduces foreign dependence in strategic sectors.*

Syllabus: GS3: Science & Technology, Defence

financialexpress.com: [read the source](#)

PRELIMS FACTS

Concrete developments worth a quick read: exercises, pacts, Acts, approvals, schemes, species, verdicts.

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

SCHEME

QUICK READ

EXERCISE TARANG SHAKTI 2026: "POWER IN PARTNERSHIP"

The Indian Air Force is hosting the second edition of the multinational air combat exercise Tarang Shakti 2026 from 26 September to 12 October 2026. The operational phase of the exercise is being conducted at Air Force Station Jodhpur and adjoining air bases under the theme Power in Partnership. Eight Friendly Foreign Countries including Australia, Bangladesh, France, Germany, Greece, Sri Lanka, UAE, and USA are participating with air assets.

[ForumIAS: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

AGREEMENT/MOU

QUICK READ

Bangladesh, US sign MoU on strategic civil nuclear cooperation

Bangladesh and the United States signed a memorandum of understanding on strategic civil nuclear cooperation to advance the peaceful use of nuclear energy. The agreement was signed in New York on Friday by Bangladesh Prime Minister's Adviser for Science and Technology Rehan Asad and US Under Secretary of State for Economic Growth, Energy and the Environment Jacob Helberg.

[Economic Times: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

PLACE IN NEWS

QUICK READ

Iran offers to reopen Strait of Hormuz in 7 days if US lifts blockade, waives sanctions

Iran offered to reopen the strategic Strait of Hormuz within seven days if the United States lifts its naval blockade of Iranian ports. The proposal also requires the US to waive sanctions on Iranian oil sales and observe a ceasefire including Lebanon. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi detailed the plan to reporters outside the UN Security Council.

[BusinessLine: source](#)

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

Exercise VARUNA 2026

INS Trishul arrived at Toulon, France, to participate in the 24th edition of the bilateral maritime exercise VARUNA. Exercise VARUNA is a bilateral maritime exercise conducted between the Indian Navy and the French Navy. Bilateral naval exercises between India and France began in 1993 and were officially christened as VARUNA in 2001. The 2026 edition of the exercise is being hosted by France at the Toulon Naval Base.

[ForumIAS: source](#)

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

At UN, Russia backs India's bid for permanent Security Council seat

Russian foreign minister Sergey Lavrov expressed support for India and Brazil to get permanent seats on the United Nations Security Council. Lavrov stated that UN Security Council reform must broaden representation for Asia, Africa, and Latin America. Russia opposed adding any Western nations, specifically naming Germany and Japan, to the Security Council permanent seats due to alleged militarism and revanchism.

[Hindustan Times: source](#)

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

AGREEMENT/MOU

QUICK READ

IIWW 2026: India and Netherlands sign two MoUs to advance Kalpasar water project

India and the Netherlands signed two Tripartite Memoranda of Understanding to advance the Kalpasar water project in Gujarat. The agreements were signed on the sidelines of the 9th India International Water Week 2026 in New Delhi. Jal Shakti Minister CR Paatil and Dutch Vice Minister Jaap Slootmaker co-chaired the bilateral meeting. The MoUs involve the Central Water Commission, Kalpasar Department of Gujarat, and Dutch institutions Deltares and TU Delft.

newsonair.gov.in: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Centre notifies Kandla, JNPA, Mundra and Paradip as mega ports

The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways designated Paradip Port as a Mega Port on 25 September 2026 under Section 73 of the Indian Ports Act, 2025. Paradip Port is the only port on India's eastern coast to receive this statutory Mega Port status. Three other ports notified alongside Paradip are Deendayal Port (Kandla) in Gujarat, Jawaharlal Nehru Port (JNPA) at Nhava Sheva in Mumbai, and Mundra Port in Gujarat.

gktoday.in: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

SPECIES

QUICK READ

New species of ancient fungus discovered on a 12-Million-Year-Old fossilised leaf from Himachal

The discovery of the new ancient fungus species on a fossilised leaf from the Siwalik sediments was recently reported. Researchers have discovered a new species of ancient fungus preserved on a 12-million-year-old fossilised leaf found in Himachal Pradesh.

Research Matters: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

JUDGMENT

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Validity of Section 28 of Gold Control Act Upheld: Supreme Court Clarifies Delegation Limits

The Supreme Court delivered a judgment on the validity and delegation limits of Section 28 of the Gold Control Act. The Supreme Court upheld the validity of Section 28 of the Gold Control Act and clarified the limits of legislative delegation.

thelawobserver.in: source

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

QUICK READ

Jitendra Singh launches commercial use of bio-based biodegradable PLA plastic

Science and Technology Minister Dr Jitendra Singh launched the commercial use of bio-based biodegradable plastic derived from Polylactic Acid (PLA). This initiative is part of the Government's BioE3 (Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment) framework. Balrampur Chini Mills Limited (BCML) is taking forward the initiative by establishing a pilot-scale facility at its integrated manufacturing complex in Kumbhi, Uttar Pradesh.

newsonair.gov.in: source

ENVIRONMENT & ECOLOGY

REPORT/INDEX

SPECIES

QUICK READ

Vulture survey begins in Wayanad Wildlife Sanctuary

The survey has begun in the sanctuary to aid conservation efforts for scavengers. A comprehensive survey has been initiated to document the status and distribution of vultures within the Wayanad Wildlife Sanctuary. Survey aims to document the status and distribution of vultures in Wayanad and aid conservation efforts for the ecologically important scavengers

The Hindu: source

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

QUICK READ

Cabinet panel approves Rs. 17,167-crore outer harbour project at VOC Port in Thoothukudi

The infrastructure project was recently cleared by the Cabinet panel to boost port capacity. The Cabinet panel approved an outer harbour project worth Rs. 17,167 crore at the V.O. Chidambaranar Port in Thoothukudi. The infrastructure project is expected to lay the foundation for the next phase of growth at the port

BusinessLine: source

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS

QUICK READ

English Translation of Prime Minister's Opening Remarks during the 18th BRICS Summit Session: "Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability: Shaping the Future for Inclusive Global Growth" (September 13, 2026)

The Ministry of External Affairs released the English translation of the Prime Minister's opening remarks. The Prime Minister of India delivered opening remarks at the 18th BRICS Summit session focusing on inclusive global growth.

Ministry of External Affairs: source

DEFENCE

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

SkyStriker Kamikaze drones successfully test-fired by Indian Army in Exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026

The successful test-firing during Exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026 put the SkyStriker drones in the news. The Indian Army successfully test-fired SkyStriker Kamikaze drones during Exercise Yudh Abhyas 2026.

The Economic Times: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

JUDGMENT

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Supreme Court Upholds Union of India in Foreign Exchange Regulation Act Case on Retrospective Applicability of Adjudication Proceedings. Amendments to Foreign Exchange Regulation Act, 1947 introducing adjudication under Sections 23(1) and 23D were

The Supreme Court pronounced its verdict on the retrospective applicability of amendments to the Foreign Exchange Regulation Act, 1947. The Supreme Court delivered a judgment upholding the Union of India regarding the retrospective applicability of adjudication proceedings under the Foreign Exchange Regulation Act.

[Lawtext: source](#)

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

JUDGMENT

ACT/BILL/RULES

QUICK READ

Supreme Court Upholds High Court Judgment Striking Down Karnataka Amendment Levying Special Additional Tax on Excess Passengers. State Legislature Lacks Competence Under Entry 57 of List II to Impose Per-Occasion Tax on Overloaded Vehicles as

The Supreme Court delivered its judgment upholding the High Court ruling on legislative competence. The Supreme Court confirmed the striking down of a Karnataka state amendment that imposed a special additional tax on vehicles carrying excess passengers.

[Lawtext: source](#)

INFRASTRUCTURE & ENERGY

QUICK READ

India's First Port-based e-Methanol Production Facility to Produce and Supply Green Fuel to Ships

The foundation stone was laid for India's first port-based e-methanol production facility at Kandla, Gujarat, involving an investment of Rs 2,300 crore. The 150-tonne-per-day green fuel plant is a joint venture between Deendayal Port Authority (DPA) and Assam Petro-Chemicals Ltd (APCL). It will use renewable power, water, and biogenic CO₂ to produce e-methanol for international vessels on the Asia-Europe trade corridor.

[PIB: source](#)

AGRICULTURE & ALLIED

QUICK READ

Cabinet approves farmer organisation policy, to be in force until March 2031

The Goa state cabinet approved the Goa Farmer Producer Organisations (FPO) Policy, 2026 to strengthen institutional coordination, professional management, finance, and infrastructure. The policy will remain in force until March 31, 2031, with provisions for review, amendment, or extension by the government. It aims to help farmers access credit, adopt technology, improve market access, add value, and converge central and state schemes.

timesofindia.indiatimes.com: source

DEFENCE

SPECIES

EXERCISE

QUICK READ

Indian, Mongolian troops conduct weapon handling drills during Exercise NOMADIC ELEPHANT

Indian and Mongolian troops are conducting intensive training activities during the 18th edition of Exercise NOMADIC ELEPHANT 2026 in Pithoragarh, Uttarakhand. The exercise takes place at the Foreign Training Node from September 21 to October 3, aiming to enhance interoperability and tactical proficiency. Mongolian Armed Forces personnel underwent weapon handling and firing training on small arms systems, covering safety drills and aiming techniques.

[aninews.in: source](#)

DEFENCE

QUICK READ

Defence Ministry signs over Rs. 810 crore contract with BDL for 160 SAT-SAAW systems

The Defence Ministry signed a contract worth over 810 crore rupees with Bharat Dynamics Limited for 160 Satellite Smart Anti-Airfield Weapons. The procurement includes associated equipment for the Indian Air Force and was signed in New Delhi in the presence of Defence Secretary Rajesh Kumar Singh. The delivery of the SAT-SAAW systems is scheduled to take place between the years 2027-2028 and 2028-2029.

newsonair.gov.in: source

POLITY & CONSTITUTION

JUDGMENT

QUICK READ

Lieutenant Governor Approves Leh as Venue for High Court Bench in Ladakh

Ladakh Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena approved Leh as the initial place of sitting for the High Court Bench in Ladakh. The decision was taken following the recommendation of the Chief Justice of the High Court of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. A total of 423 cases are pending from the Union Territory of Ladakh, with 252 cases originating from the Leh Division.

drishtias.com: source

INTERNAL SECURITY

APPOINTMENT

QUICK READ

Who Is Ajit Lal? Former IB Special Director Appointed New Interlocutor for Indo-Naga Talks

The Government of India has appointed retired IPS officer Ajit Lal as the new interlocutor for the Indo-Naga political dialogue. The NSCN (IM) has welcomed Ajit Lal's appointment, calling it a significant and encouraging development that shows the Centre's resolve. The negotiation framework is expected to include a Union minister or a group of Union ministers to help expedite the process.

indianmasterminds.com: source

EDITORIAL WATCH

What the opinion pages argued: two or three lines each.

GS3 Revisiting India's nuclear doctrine without revising it

India's nuclear doctrine, operationalised in 2003, rests on credible minimum deterrence, a No First Use (NFU) posture, and massive retaliation. The security environment has shifted due to a closer China-Pakistan alignment, technological disruptions like AI and hypersonics, and a multipolar Indo-Pacific. Emerging technologies shorten decision-making timelines and complicate assumptions about assured retaliation and command-and-control resilience. A periodic review of doctrines is ordinary statecraft, but any signal of revising core principles like NFU could squander the asset of predictability.

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Don't Export Tomorrow's Wheat Surplus Today

Central Pool wheat stocks reached 57.8 MMT, including 22 MMT carry-forward stocks and 35.8 MMT fresh procurement during 2026-27. The government requires about 21 MMT for welfare schemes and 7.5 MMT as a buffer stock, leaving stocks above these essential needs. India has reopened wheat exports after allowing 2.5 MMT each in February and April, with exports expected to rise to around 2 MMT in 2026-27.

[ForumIAS](#)

GS3 Narrowed posture: On Karnataka and the Kasturirangan Report

The Karnataka cabinet recently decided to reject the Kasturirangan report, prompting fresh debate on Western Ghats conservation. The editorial critiques Karnataka's total rejection of the Kasturirangan report on Ecologically Sensitive Areas in the Western Ghats, urging a more balanced preservation strategy. Karnataka must not reject the entire framework of ecologically sensitive areas

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 In Xi-Trump summit pomp, pageantry has postponed pressure

Chinese President Xi Jinping received an extraordinary state reception in Washington DC, marking his first state visit in a decade. The US-China trade truce has been extended by two months until January 2027 to fashion a more durable trade deal. Both leaders reached a broad agreement on artificial intelligence, agreeing that it must be kept under human control.

[Hindustan Times](#)

GS3 Inflation has already produced grievous distortion in our economy: G N Lawande

The author argues that nine years of economic planning have failed to tackle the problem of inflation in India. Inflationary pressures grew strong during the Second Five Year Plan and are expected to worsen during the Third Five Year Plan due to deficit financing. The root cause of inflation is traced back to government fiscal policies and wartime conditions, characterized by investment exceeding savings.

[ThePrint](#)

GS2 UPSC Editorial Analysis: Counterfeit Medicines and Health System Vulnerabilities

The seizure of counterfeit, expired, and mislabelled critical medicines in Bengaluru exposes severe systemic weaknesses within India's pharmaceutical supply chain. Unscrupulous operators repackaged cheap or expired formulations using forged invoices and licenses to distribute fake oncology and ICU drugs. Spurious life-saving medications were sold to hospitals and pharmacies at steep discounts of up to 50% to exploit price-sensitive procurement. Inter-state operations successfully exploited regulatory boundaries, enforcement gaps, and the dual regulatory architecture split between the Centre and States.

[Insights on India](#)

GS3 Growth holds up for now. Inflation clouds outlook

Global agencies like the Asian Development Bank, S&P Global, OECD, and Moody's have raised India's full-year growth estimates to about 7 per cent following strong first-quarter GDP numbers. The Index of Industrial Production grew by 6.3 per cent and manufacturing grew by 7 per cent during April to July. Central capital expenditure surged by almost 30 per cent and merchandise goods exports grew by 17.8 per cent between April and August.

[civildaily.com](#)

GS2 The case for accountable lottery regulation in India

The Lotteries Regulation Act of 1998 permits states to organise lotteries and allows states to prohibit lotteries organised by other states. B.R. Enterprises vs State of U.P. (1999) ruled that a state can exclude other states' lotteries only by abandoning its own lottery operations. Outright bans fail to eliminate demand, instead pushing vulnerable players towards illegal channels, smuggled tickets, and unlicensed numbers betting. Tamil Nadu in 2003 and Karnataka in 2007 chose total prohibition, forfeiting accountable public lottery options and losing tax and non-tax revenues.

[The Hindu](#)

GS3 Job scheme: Address the sharp decline in numbers

The editorial highlights a sharp decline in employment numbers under the new rural job scheme, raising concerns about its structural design. A major structural hurdle is the shift from a centrally-funded model to one where most states must now contribute 40 percent of the cost. While temporary factors like the sowing season or transition delays play a role, they do not fully explain the massive dip in employment generation.

[tribuneindia.com](#)

GS2 Trump-XI summit : Extension of trade truce signals status quo

The Washington summit between US President Donald Trump and Chinese President Xi Jinping resulted in an extension of their trade truce for another two months. Despite the short-term relief, fundamental disputes over tariffs, American goods purchases, rare-earth supplies, and advanced technology restrictions remain unresolved. On Taiwan, Xi Jinping urged Washington to oppose its independence and handle the issue with prudence, while the US maintains its strategic ambiguity.

[tribuneindia.com](#)

GS2 Overweight and weak: On the UN, the 81st session of the UN General Assembly

The convening of the 81st session of the UN General Assembly. An editorial discussing the structural weaknesses and superpower dominance affecting the United Nations during its 81st General Assembly session. The United Nations is unwieldy, and needs to move away from superpower hegemony

[The Hindu](#)

GS2 BRICS khichdi simmering in the global pot

The 11-member BRICS formation acts as a geopolitical counterbalance to the G-7 and Western-dominated global order. BRICS functions as a diverse mix of nations with divergent ideologies, serving as a multi-polar coalition. Khichdi, tracing its origins to the Indian subcontinent over 2,000 years ago, serves as an apt metaphor for this diverse bloc. Ancient texts like Charaka Samhita and Mahabharata mention khichdi, and historical figures like Megasthenes and Ibn Batuta documented it.

[Economic Times](#)

GS1 GS3 India could be 26% richer if more women join workforce

India's female labour force participation rate (LFPR) stood at 34.4% for July 2026, slightly above Saudi Arabia's 33.6% for 2025. Studies indicate that bringing more women into the workforce could make India 26% richer than it currently is. Richer households in India often discourage women from working outside the home to flex their social status. Increased schooling among women has sometimes functioned as a societal tool to increase marriage market attractiveness rather than labour market entry.

[Economic Times](#)

GS2 Walkouts, threats, memes—why the UNGA now feels more like theatre than diplomacy

Over 100 UN delegates walked out of the General Assembly chamber as Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu approached the podium for the second year in a row. Iran labelled Netanyahu the 'Dark Lord' on social media, while its Ghana embassy likened him to 'Voldemort' and allied countries to 'Death Eaters'. The 81st session of the General Assembly opened under the theme 'Restoring trust, managing transformation: a United Nations that delivers for all.'

[ThePrint](#)

GS2 US can no longer ignore China's rise

Donald Trump hosted China's Xi Jinping with full honors at the Pentagon and a State banquet attended by allies like Elon Musk. Washington and Beijing are working toward a mutually beneficial rapprochement, driven by Trump's dealmaker instincts and Beijing's economic ambitions. Trump aims to negotiate hard regarding America's dependence on Chinese rare-earth minerals and technological competition. Xi Jinping seeks to eliminate impediments to China's economic growth and geopolitical regional ambitions.

[Hindustan Times](#)

EXPLAINED

The concept behind the news, one or two lines each.

The takeaways from Trump-Xi summit: Plenty of show, little of substance The summit took place, prompting an analysis of its takeaways and its specific implications for Indian foreign policy. The text outlines the outcomes of the Trump-Xi summit, highlighting a lack of substantial agreements and noting emerging concerns for India.

[Indian Express](#)

India's Nuclear Doctrine – Advantages & Challenges India's nuclear doctrine, formally articulated in 2003 by the Cabinet Committee on Security, centers on No First Use and Credible Minimum Deterrence. The No First Use policy dictates that India will not use nuclear weapons first in a conflict but will retaliate massively if attacked.

[ForumIAS](#)

When the referee fumbles: Election Commission row explained in 7 key questions Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi reportedly objected to decisions and communications issued by Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar without their knowledge over the past 10 months. The objections covered changes to Form 6 for voter registration, restrictions on access to the ERONet voter database, and work allocation changes removing IT infrastructure oversight.

[Times of India](#)

Knowledge Nugget | How does the Election Commission allocate election symbols? Published as a Knowledge Nugget by Indian Express for UPSC current affairs preparation. An explainer detailing the legal framework and procedure used by the Election Commission of India to reserve and allocate symbols to political parties and candidates.

[Indian Express](#)

AFSPA extended in Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal Pradesh: What does the law mean? The Ministry of Home Affairs extended the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958, for another six months starting October 1. The extension covers most parts of Manipur, several districts of Nagaland, and certain districts of Arunachal Pradesh.

[telanganatoday.com](#)

Expert Explains | Why the Trump-Xi bonhomie doesn't mean an end to US and China's rivalry The topic is in the news due to interactions and public displays of warmth between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping. An explainer analyzing why diplomatic bonhomie between Donald Trump and Xi Jinping does not eliminate the fundamental strategic rivalry between the US and China.

[Indian Express](#)

ECI-SIR Row: Is CEC Gyanesh Kumar Immune From Arrest? How An SC Petition Is Countering It A petition filed in the Supreme Court questioning the arrest immunity of the Chief Election Commissioner brought the issue into the headlines. An explainer on the Supreme Court petition challenging the immunity from arrest claimed or implied for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar amid the ECI-SIR row.

[thedailyjagran.com](#)

What are IRDAI's proposed insurance reforms, why have they hit insurance stocks? IRDAI has proposed major changes covering Expense of Management limits, commission structures, and safeguards against mis-selling. The framework introduces separate caps on commissions based on insurance products, complexity, and distribution channels. Commissions for open architecture models like banks and brokers are proposed to be lower, restricted to 2% to 5% for insurance sold alongside loans.

[msn.com](#)

Import duty cut on edible oils ahead of festivals The Centre reduced the basic customs duty on major imported crude edible oils to moderate domestic prices and provide consumer relief. The basic customs duty on crude sunflower oil was reduced from 10% to nil. The basic customs duty on crude soybean and palm oil was cut from 10% to 5%.

[newindianexpress.com](#)

Tamil links to West Asia: What underwater excavations in Chola capital reveal Recent underwater archaeological explorations have brought fresh discoveries regarding ancient Tamil maritime trade to light. Underwater excavations in the ancient Chola capital reveal historical trade and cultural connections between Tamil Nadu and West Asia.

[Indian Express](#)

First Agniveer batch set to return: How Uttarakhand is trying to help them find jobs The first batch of Agniveers inducted under the Agnipath scheme is approaching the completion of their four-year service tenure. The Uttarakhand state government is preparing measures and job assistance programs to help the first batch of returning Agniveers integrate into the civilian workforce after completing their four-year tenure.

[Indian Express](#)

What is moral disengagement? How does it enable otherwise ordinary individuals to participate in unethical conduct? The concept is frequently analyzed in contemporary behavioral science and governance discussions to explain how ordinary people participate in large-scale corruption or unethical organizational practices.

[Insights on India](#)

ALSO IN THE NEWS

Reactions, previews and smaller stories: one line each.

- It's not BRICS or UN, BRICS is supportive of UN: Jaishankar (International Relations) [The Hindu](#)
- PM Modi's SCO visit is loaded with expectations on BRICS Summit and UNSC election (International Relations) [The Hindu](#)
- Arguments by serial practitioner of terrorism will not stand: EAM Jaishankar slams Pakistan at UNGA (International Relations) [Hindustan Times](#)
- Union Minister to join Naga peace negotiations; encouraging: NSCN (IM) (Internal Security) [Indian Express](#)
- Jaishankar calls targeting of commercial shipping, seafarers 'simply unacceptable' amid Gulf conflict (International Relations) [BusinessLine](#)
- Analogue Paneer: FSSAI Rules, Ingredients & Food Safety (Governance & Policy) [Insights on India](#)
- Indian non-profits lag on digital maturity, AI adoption: report (Governance & Policy) [The Hindu](#)
- Super El Nino and Impacts on Weather (Environment & Ecology) [ForumIAS](#)
- 'Zero tolerance on terrorism': Jaishankar says India will exercise its right to defend itself at UNGA (International Relations) [Moneycontrol.com](#)
- RBI Bulletin – September 2026 (Economy) [RBI](#)
- Namya River (Geography) [ForumIAS](#)
- India stresses resilient health systems, pandemic preparedness at UN (Health) [Hindustan Times](#)
- India vs Pakistan at UNGA: Diplomats trade charges over terrorism, Kashmir & Indus water treaty (International Relations) [The Economic Times](#)
- The Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA) (Internal Security) [Insights on India](#)
- Subansiri Upper Hydroelectric Project and Subansiri River (Environment & Ecology) [ForumIAS](#)
- India's election commission orders review of voter-roll changes (Polity & Constitution) [Devdiscourse](#)
- Jammu and Kashmir LoP meets Union Home Minister a day after introduction of Statehood resolution (Polity & Constitution) [The Hindu](#)
- India extends anti-dumping duty on decor paper imports from China till March 2027 (Economy) [News On AIR](#)
- Centre notifies two offshore mineral blocks near Great Nicobar (Economy) [The Indian Express](#)
- Maharashtra Declares Drought in 75% of the State (Disaster Management) [The Indian Express](#)

- PM Modi Highlights India's Commitment to Protecting Greater One-Horned Rhinoceros on World Rhino Day (Environment & Ecology) [News On AIR](#)
- EAM Jaishankar meets Russia's Lavrov on UNGA sidelines, reviews bilateral and BRICS cooperation (International Relations) [ANI News](#)
- India to consult industry on trade secrets law, whistleblower safeguards and contract enforcement (Economy) [Economic Times](#)
- Bangladesh launches measles vaccination drive amid deadly outbreak (Health) [The Hindu](#)
- India's financial, external sectors remain resilient despite global risks: RBI bulletin (Economy) [Mint](#)
- Keralam power crisis: KSEB makes fresh attempt at tapping coal linkage under SHAKTI policy (Infrastructure & Energy) [The Hindu](#)
- CBSE Appoints Mandeep K. Bhandari as New Chairperson to Lead the Central Board of Secondary Education (Governance & Policy) [Entrepreneur India](#)
- India, Japan Discuss Defence Technology Cooperation, Joint Exercises and Indo-Pacific Security (International Relations) [News On AIR](#)
- Supreme Court Dismisses Writ Petition Challenging Its Own Order Under Article 136 in Land Acquisition Matter. Holding That a Judgment or Order Passed by the Supreme Court Under Article 136 Cannot Be Judicially Reviewed Under Article 32, the Court Rea (Polity & Constitution) [lawtext.in](#)
- Election Commission Dismisses Rift Claims, Extends SIR Deadlines in Delhi and Maharashtra (Polity & Constitution) [India Today](#)
- Jaishankar meets Russia, Iran at UN after Trump sanctions law (International Relations) [India Today](#)
- EAM S Jaishankar, UAE and French counterparts discuss AI, space, energy and culture (International Relations) [All India Radio \(NewsOnAir\)](#)
- EAM S Jaishankar co-chairs event on 'AI in the Context of International Peace and Security' in New York (International Relations) [All India Radio \(NewsOnAir\)](#)
- ECI revises SIR notices after Indian Express report — and puts out a unity photo (Polity & Constitution) [NewsLaundry](#)
- Declaration part of Form 6 changed since SIR in Bihar (Polity & Constitution) [Civildaily](#)
- IIST Shibpur, TCS sign MoU to establish Centre of Excellence in Artificial Intelligence (Science & Technology) [Telegraph India](#)
- India's National Statement at the 81st session of the UN General Assembly (International Relations) [Ministry of External Affairs](#)
- Senior Citizens Act | Tribunal Can't Declare Gift Deed Void On Ground Of Forgery; Remedy Lies Before... (Social Justice & Welfare) [LiveLaw](#)
- Supreme Court Seeks IRDAI Data On Insurance Policies Issued To Persons With Disabilities (Social Justice & Welfare) [LawBeat](#)
- ICG Ship Shaunak Sails for Australia with Quad Officers Aboard (Defence) [Bharatshakti](#)
- Adult Franchise Going Away Thanks To Supreme Court & Election Commission: Senior Advocate Dushyant Dave... (Polity & Constitution) [livelaw.in](#)
- Women SSCWO Permanent Commission: Supreme Court's 2026 Pooja Pal Judgment Explained (Polity & Constitution) [Legal Service India](#)
- The Anti-Goonda Bill, 2026 (Polity & Constitution) [Insights on India](#)
- Over 18K Cases Pending In NCDRC As On July 31, 2026 : Report Before Supreme Court (Governance & Policy) [LiveLaw](#)
- Naga leaders agree to open key Manipur highway after talks with Centre in Assam (Internal Security) [Indian Express](#)
- West Bengal govt to sign MoUs for four airports to boost regional air connectivity (Infrastructure & Energy) [News On AIR](#)
- Foreign Ministers of BRICS to exchange views on global & regional issues of mutual interest: MEA (International Relations) [News On AIR](#)
- Super Powers: From Viceroy's lavish feasts to BRICS vegetarian menus, how India's diplomatic dining change (History, Art & Culture) [economictimes.com](#)
- NDA allies break rank, demand transparency from Election Commission chief (Polity & Constitution) [Mint](#)
- Shehbaz Sharif's 'act of war' warning over Indus waters at UN; India hits back over terrorism (International Relations) [Indian Express](#)
- Strengthening India's Space Sovereignty (Science & Technology) [PIB](#)
- PMFAI Opposes Five-Year Regulatory Data Protection for Agrochemicals (Agriculture & Allied) [chemindigest.com](#)
- Jairam Ramesh targets Centre over CEC appointment law, says Bill "bulldozed" in 2023 (Polity & Constitution) [ANI News](#)

COVERAGE CHECK

Items — 21 must-know, 22 Prelims facts, 53 in the news, 15 editorials, 12 explainers.

Syllabus areas in the cards — International Relations (8), Polity & Constitution (8), Environment & Ecology (6), Defence (5), Infrastructure & Energy (4), Economy (3), Science & Technology (2), Social Justice & Welfare (2), Agriculture & Allied (2), Governance & Policy (1), Health (1), Internal Security (1). **Nothing today in** — Education, Disaster Management, History, Art & Culture, Geography, Society, Ethics & Integrity.

Easy-miss watch — Marine & coastal (EEZ, UNCLOS, Blue Economy, deep sea): 2 · Digital Public Infrastructure & data governance: 2 · Political change in the neighbourhood: 1 · Appointments to constitutional / statutory / regulatory bodies: 4 · Defence-technology cooperation agreements: 2

Full text — 46 of 70 items were read in full from a free copy; the rest are summarised from the outlets' reports. Subscriber-only sites are never opened.

Sources in the cards — The Hindu 8, ForumIAS 6, Economic Times 6, Indian Express 5, Hindustan Times 4, gktoday.in 3, newsonair.gov.in 3, indianmasterminds.com 2, Research Matters 2, BusinessLine 2, Lawtext 2, Insights on India 2, tribuneindia.com 2, ThePrint 2

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